The influential section of Delhi society had earlier never bothered about any *challans*. There were innumerable cases wherein these *challans* had been torn to shreds in front of the issuing officer with a 'do-what-you-want' attitude. But spot-fining, the people soon realized, was a different ball game altogether. No amount of influence and no friends, however highly placed, could help out here. Kiran had given clear-cut instructions to her men to stand by her orders and that she would back their actions to the hilt. She was not going to assess their work by the number of *challans* but by the quality of traffic management both in enforcement and regulation.

A lobby that resented her soon began to take shape. After all, here they were, affluent and with a lot of pelf, in the corridors of power, and there she was just a DCP and a woman to boot! The situation must have antagonized them no end.

She made no compromises and granted no concessions. In August 1982 even Prime Minister Indira Gandhi's car (no. DHI 1817) was pulled up for wrong parking near an upholstery shop in Connaught Place and the vehicle towed away by a crane. The action of the subinspector, Nirmal Singh, who was on duty, was backed to the hilt by Kiran Bedi, and by her senior, additional commissioner of police, Ashok Tandon, whose support she enjoyed all along.

An interesting news item in the magazine *Sunday* (28 August 1982) throws more light on what happened:

PM'S CAR HELD

When the deputy police commissioner (traffic) Mrs Kiran Bedi started a drive against wrong parking last year, no one could have imagined that even the Prime Minister's car would come into the dragnet. But the impossible happened. On 5 August [1982], when Mrs Gandhi and her family members were away in the USA, a traffic subinspector found a white Ambassador (DHI 1817), wrongly parked outside the Yusufzai Market, Connaught Circus, in the heart of the city. Only after he had made out a challan did he realise that it was the official car of the PM. The securitymen accompanying the car (which had gone there for repairs), pointed this out to the traffic officer. But he was adamant. Wrong parking was illegal, whether it be by a commoner or a VIP, he told the securitymen.

An enquiry has been ordered into the incident. As soon as the PM returned from her tour, the matter was brought to her notice. The scope of the enquiry is: how was there a lack of coordination between the VIP security and the traffic wings of the Delhi police? Mrs Kiran Bedi has, however, made it public that the question of putting the heat on an officer who was merely carrying [out] his duties did not arise. The incident, meanwhile, has exposed a chink in the Delhi traffic police. The shop to which Mrs Gandhi's car went, Handa and Company, belongs to a friend of a powerful aide of the PM. The shop deals in car accessories and upholstery. The popularity of the shop attracts many car owners. But to take a car to the shop also invites a traffic challan because of the shop's location. The car park on the opposite pavement is usually overcrowded (as a popular restaurant and hotel are located there). The traffic police have been refusing to recognise the fact that as long as Handa and Babbar Sons, two popular car accessory dealers, are located at the Yusufzai Market, car owners are bound to park their cars outside the shops and get the fittings done. Though the existing traffic rules prohibit parking in that area surely this reality has to be taken into account as well. Whether the incident involving the PM's car will awaken the traffic police to the realities of the situation or not is difficult to say. But Mrs Bedi's traffic drive certainly has reached the gates of 1, Safdarjang Road [the Prime